

World in Brief: Devastation in Venezuela; renewed tensions in the Strait of Hormuz



Photograph: Getty Images

At least 188 people [are confirmed dead](#) and more than 1,500 injured after two big **earthquakes** struck **Venezuela**. There is a substantial chance that the death toll will surpass 10,000, according to the US Geological Survey. Delcy Rodríguez, [Venezuela's](#) acting president, declared a state of emergency. Electricity and telecom networks are down in parts of the country. America said it was sending search and rescue teams.

The UN's International Maritime Organisation paused plans to evacuate sailors stranded in the **Strait of Hormuz**, after reports that a Singapore-flagged cargo ship was struck [on the waterway](#). The source of the attack is unclear; some reports said **Iran's** Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps was responsible. Iran's elite military force had previously warned vessels against travelling on non-sanctioned routes.

Apple raised prices for iPads and MacBooks by around 20% worldwide. The company blamed an unprecedented [increase in the cost](#) of memory and storage chips, because of rampant demand driven by the AI boom. It left the prices of iPhones, its big profit-maker, unchanged. Several competitors, including Samsung, have made similar moves. Apple's share price fell on the news.

America's annual **inflation** rate reached its highest level in more than three years, rising to 4.2% in May, up from 3.8% in April. The increase was largely driven by the Iran war's impact on energy prices. Food inflation also accelerated. Although oil prices have fallen since [the latest deal](#) between America and Iran, the figures make an interest-rate rise by the Federal Reserve this year look more likely.

America's **Supreme Court** issued several rulings in line with the Trump administration's wishes. It determined that migrants could not claim asylum if they did not physically enter the country, enabling them to be turned back at the border. It also scrapped protections of Haitians' and Syrians' rights to work and live in the country. And it struck down a law restricting the right to carry guns in Hawaii.

Jamie Dimon appointed Doug Petno and Troy Rohrbaugh, two insiders, as co-presidents of **JPMorgan Chase**, making them probable frontrunners to succeed him as head of the bank. Succession speculation has raged for years; Mr Dimon has led the bank for two decades and will not say when he plans to retire. Under his tenure [the bank has eclipsed](#) other Wall Street lenders in size and profitability.

Prosecutors in Manhattan dropped a rape charge against **Harvey Weinstein** after his accuser declined to testify in another trial. In 2024 New York's top court [overturned felony sex-crime charges](#) against the Hollywood mogul, deeming his 2020 trial unfair. He was convicted of sexual assault and acquitted of another charge after retrials, but juries were twice undecided on this final case. Mr Weinstein denies the allegations.

Figure of the day: \$3trn, the estimated amount that will go into AI data centres globally between 2026 and 2030. But [opposition is also spreading](#).

Correction: A previous edition of the World in Brief stated that SK Hynix was the world's second-largest chipmaker. It is the world's second-large memory-chip maker. Sorry.

Bad blood between Poland and Ukraine



Photograph: Getty Images

The Ukraine Recovery Conference, a now annual summit which began on Thursday, is hosted by Poland this year. It was meant to reaffirm the country's support for its war-torn neighbour. Instead, it will thrust their [testy relationship](#) into the spotlight.

Last month Ukraine named a military unit after the Ukrainian Insurgent Army, a guerilla group accused of massacring some 100,000 Poles during the second world war. After Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, refused to rename the unit, his Polish counterpart, Karol Nawrocki (pictured), stripped him of the Order of the White Eagle, Poland's highest decoration. On Tuesday Mr Zelensky dropped out of the conference, sending Yulia Svyrydenko, his prime minister, in his stead.

It is only the latest skirmish. A row over grain exports in 2023 prompted Poland to suspend weapons deliveries. The fallout from this row may be painful for cash-strapped Ukraine, and is embarrassing for Poland's pro-European government, which is at odds with its hard-right president.

No truce in the fight against inflation



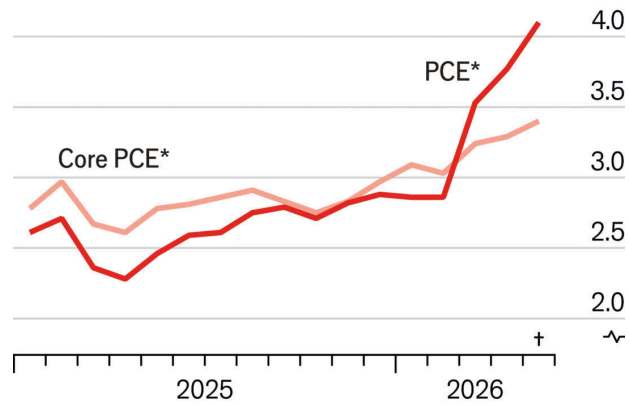
Photograph: EPA

Kevin Warsh revealed little at his first policy meeting as Federal Reserve chair last week. He brushed questions aside with a wry: “We have a task force for that.” Yet investors heard a [hawkish message](#). Mr Warsh insisted that inflation in America remains too high and Fed officials are “unanimous” in their commitment to price stability. Half of the central bank’s policymakers foresaw at least one rate rise this year; six pencilled in two or more. Markets now assign roughly a one-in-three chance of a hike as soon as July.

The next test comes on Thursday, when America’s Bureau of Economic Analysis releases the personal-consumption-expenditures price index for May, the Fed’s preferred inflation gauge. Economists expect headline inflation of 4% over the past year, and core inflation, which strips out food and energy, of 3.4%. A [tentative America-Iran deal](#) is already easing [energy prices](#). But if it frays, Mr Warsh’s task will become clearer: keeping rates high.

Up for the challenge

United States, consumer prices,
% increase on a year earlier



*Personal-consumption expenditures †Forecast

Source: Haver Analytics

A match with Mexican history



Photograph: EPA

King Felipe of Spain travels to Mexico on Thursday for some [football diplomacy](#). Before watching his national team play Uruguay in Guadalajara in the [World Cup](#) he will meet Claudia Sheinbaum, Mexico's president. It is an effort to end seven years of tension between Spain and the largest Spanish-speaking country, both of which have left-of-centre governments.

The trouble began when Ms Sheinbaum's predecessor and mentor, Andrés Manuel López Obrador, demanded that the king apologise for the "abuses" committed five centuries ago by Hernán Cortés and his conquistadors. He was playing domestic politics; some Spaniards suggested tartly that Mr López Obrador, a populist nationalist of Spanish descent, should himself apologise. Visiting an exhibition of Mexican archaeology in Madrid in March, the king admitted there was abuse, without directly apologising, prompting Ms Sheinbaum to invite him: high time to get the ball rolling.

Italy and France's tense friendship



Photograph: David Simonds

Giorgia Meloni, Italy's populist-right prime minister, has not always seen eye-to-eye with Emmanuel Macron, France's centrist president. Among other things she dislikes his preference for getting together with Germany and Britain in the "E3" format, which excludes Italy. But the pair will seek to make amends on Thursday at a mini-summit in Antibes on the Mediterranean. It is the first such gathering since the two countries signed a reinforced friendship treaty five years ago.

The leaders are due to discuss a range of matters, from support to Ukraine and Lebanon to industrial defence co-operation. They will put on a good display of neighbourly friendship, not least after Ms Meloni's recent spat with America's Donald Trump. He claimed that she begged him for a photo at the G7 summit in Evian-les-Bains last week in order to boost her flagging popularity. She retorted on social media that "[being your friend](#) certainly has not helped it". Mr Trump's antics are driving Europeans into each other's arms.

Straight from the horse's mouth



Photograph: Getty Images

What does a finch mean when it chirps? And what is a striped mouse thinking when it squeaks? These are the kinds of questions occupying the finalists of this year's Coller-Dolittle Prize, worth \$100,000—a competition to develop an algorithm for communicating with non-human animals. Set up by Jeremy Coller, a British billionaire investor and animal-welfare activist, the challenge is inspired by the Turing test, which assesses whether machines can think. The winner is announced on Thursday.

Scientists started working seriously on the problem of [animal cognition and communication](#) in the 1960s. But things have really picked up thanks to AI. Researchers can now use large language models to analyse huge audio datasets of grunts and caws to identify patterns. Last year's winners recorded the whistle of a bottlenose dolphin using hydrophones and acoustic tags attached to suction cups. To decode their meaning, they observed the reactions other dolphins had when the recordings were played back at them.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which American oil tycoon haggled with the kidnappers when his grandson was taken in 1973?

Wednesday: Which actor rose to fame playing a modern version of Sherlock Holmes before playing Dr Strange in various Marvel movies?

*Speak across borders even if
borders pass through every word.*

Ingeborg Bachmann